WRENFORD BOROUGH COUNCIL

Highways Policy

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1. Purpose

This policy says how Wrenford Borough Council deals with reports of street defects: who opens the review of a report and who decides it, how a report is screened against its defect type's own standard and its linked type's, when coordination with other works must come first, what each decision means and what it sends out, how the report queue is ordered, and what customer services may be told.

It applies to every report made through the website, the StreetCare app or the contact centre of a carriageway, footway, drainage, vegetation or street lighting defect. Each report is reviewed under the defect standard of its own defect type, and of its linked defect type where it has one.

2. Roles

- **Street Care Coordinator** - works in the street care office, opens the review of a report from the report queue and states what the review should look at; the review, with the decision it recommends, then waits for a Highways Inspector. A review is opened once for each revision of a report, and a Street Care Coordinator never decides one.
- **Highways Inspector** - is appointed for the streets of one inspection district, as section 3 sets out; may open a review of a report on those streets, and decides any review of a report on those streets that they did not open: orders the repair, sends the report for inspection on site, or refers it for coordination.
- **Reporter** - the resident, business, councillor, bus operator or school who reports the defect through a channel, and who is sent the resident update when a repair is ordered.
- **Network coordination team** - books road space and traffic management, and agrees with the utilities whose street works are live how a repair fits around their works, for every report referred for coordination.
- **Customer Services Adviser** - answers residents' calls, and asks about the defect standards, this policy, the Report Rules and the statement guides, about a defect report only as section 11 allows, and about a street only as section 12 allows.

3. Separation of opening and deciding

The person who opens a review may not decide it. Every review is decided by a Highways Inspector appointed for the report's street who did not open it, and the decision is recorded with the Highways Inspector's account.

Each Highways Inspector is appointed for one inspection district: the Town Centre - High Street, Market Place, Church Street, Station Road, Bridge Street, King Street, Castle Street, Mill Lane, Chapel Row, Bank Parade, Sheep Street and Wool Lane; North - Northgate, Park Avenue, Hillside Road, Beech Grove, Oakfield Drive, Meadow Close, Cedar Way, Kingsley Road, Orchard Rise, Windmill Lane, Grange Road and Hawthorn Close; South - London Road, Southfield Road, Riverside Walk, Victoria Road, Albert Street, Canal Street, Elm Terrace, Willow Crescent, Brook Lane, Foundry Lane, Tannery Close and Ferry Lane; or the Villages - Ashby Road, Long Lane, Back Lane, School Lane, The Green, Pond Lane, Holloway Lane, Top Road, Moor Lane, Clay Pit Lane, Littleworth and Kiln Lane. Two Highways Inspectors are appointed for each district, so that one can decide what the other opened.

A recommendation, however it was produced, is only a recommendation. Nothing is sent, and no repair is ordered, no inspection requested and no report referred, until the decision is recorded. Tools may screen the report, read the documents, work out the figures and draft the works order and the resident update, but ordering a repair is never a machine's to decide.

4. Reports, linked defects and the street works register

A defect that is two defect types at once - a pothole holding water from a blocked gully, standing water on a broken footway, a hedge over a broken footway, branches hanging over a street light - is reported once, under the defect type the reporter chooses, with the other as its linked defect type. Whichever way round it is reported, it must meet both standards. No defect type is linked to itself.

The street works register lists the street works permits on the council's streets, each Live or Cancelled, with the street, the part of the highway the works are in - the carriageway or the footway - the works promoter, a utility or the

council's own contractor, and what the works are. A cancelled permit's works will not take place, and a cancelled permit never counts for the coordination triggers.

A repair is expected to take its planned crew hours; a repair expected to take more than 1.3 times them is shown as an expected overrun, and a repair that needs a second visit is recorded as completed after a return visit.

5. What is reviewed

Every report is reviewed in four parts:

1 **The requirements.** Each requirement of the defect type's own standard, and of its linked type's, Met, Not met or Not documented on the latest revision of the report, read as the Report Rules set out.

2 **The coordination triggers.** Whether coordination must come first, as section 6 sets out.

3 **The statements.** Every sentence of every document attached to the report, read with the statement guide for its type where it has one. A measurement sentence whose figure differs from the report's, or gives a figure the report left blank, is flagged for the Highways Inspector.

4 **The figures.** The repeat likelihood and the expected crew hours, as section 10 describes.

Each defect type's requirements are read from its own standard and from no other document. The five defect standards share one layout and many of the same sentences, and the carriageway and footway standards read almost alike, so the standard is always chosen by the defect type on the report, and by its linked defect type.

6. The coordination triggers

Coordination must come first when any one of these applies:

- **live street works**: a permit live on the report's street, in the street works register, whose works are in the same part of the highway as the report's defect type or its linked type. A carriageway or drainage defect is in the carriageway, a footway defect or a street light is in the footway, and vegetation is in neither;
- **a traffic-sensitive street**: the report, or its linked type, is a carriageway or drainage defect, and the street is not a local road;
- **a high column**: the report, or its linked type, is a street light on a column taller than 8 metres, which needs a high-reach platform and a lane closure.

The permits live on the street are counted from the street works register, and a cancelled permit is never counted. A carriageway report on a street where a water main repair is live in the carriageway counts one conflicting permit; with that permit cancelled it counts none; and a permit live in the footway never conflicts with it.

A blank answer never lets a report slip past coordination: a blank street category counts as traffic sensitive, and a blank column height counts as taller than 8 metres.

7. The three decisions

The screening gives an assessment. Any requirement Not met or Not documented, under the report's own standard or its linked type's, makes it INSPECT ON SITE; otherwise any coordination trigger makes it REFER FOR COORDINATION; otherwise it is ORDER REPAIR.

The Highways Inspector chooses one of three decisions, each open only as set out here:

- **ORDER REPAIR** - the repair goes ahead from the report, and the works order and the resident update of section 8 are written. Open only when the assessment is ORDER REPAIR: every requirement Met and no coordination trigger.
- **INSPECT ON SITE** - an inspector visits the defect and measures it before anything is repaired, with the inspection request that section 8 describes. Always open, because a report is never closed from the desk.
- **REFER FOR COORDINATION** - the report goes to the network coordination team with its review, where the repair is fitted around the street works, the traffic and the platform it needs. Always open.

A decision that is not open is refused, and so is a decision by the person who opened the review, a decision by a Highways Inspector not appointed for the report's street, a decision on a review already decided, and a decision while another is being recorded.

The report's record moves from awaiting a decision to repair ordered, inspection requested or referred for coordination, and keeps the review, the decision, the Highways Inspector, the documents written and every step of

the review. A report sent again with more detail is the next revision of the same report, and that revision is reviewed afresh.

8. Documents and the coordination brief

When a Highways Inspector orders a repair, the works order is written to the council's repair contractor, as section 7 of the defect type's standard sets out, and then the resident update, as its section 8 sets out.

When a report is sent for inspection, an inspection request is written to the inspector who will visit. It names every requirement not met or not documented, with the report's own answers and the answers it needs, the "What an inspection records" section of each standard it was screened under, and every statement sentence flagged against the report, to be settled on site. No resident update is written.

When a report is referred, a coordination brief is built from the review's record: the report, its requirements and their results, the coordination triggers with every conflicting permit live on the street by its permit reference, the statements' flags and the figures. Nothing is written to the contractor until coordination is agreed.

Neither the works order, the inspection request nor the resident update carries a figure from a model, and the resident update never names any member of the council's staff.

9. The report queue

The report queue lists every open report - every report in the live queue - whatever its review has reached. Reports whose defect type or linked type is footway come first, because a trip injures people walking, and every other report after them, each group in order of its report reference, so that the oldest report is reviewed first. The queue is never ordered by a model's figure.

A report in the queue is awaiting review until its review is opened, awaiting a decision once the review has been written, and then repair ordered, inspection requested or referred for coordination once a Highways Inspector has decided it; a decided report stays in the queue with its decision.

10. The two figures

Two figures are shown to the Highways Inspector beside every review. They are advisory: the decisions open come from the requirements and the coordination triggers alone, neither figure decides a report, and neither appears in a works order, an inspection request or a resident update.

- **The repeat likelihood** - how likely defects like this one have been to be reported again after they were dealt with, worked out from the report history with the report's requirement results, the street works beside it and its coordination triggers. It is shown with a band: HIGH from 0.40, MEDIUM from 0.20, and LOW below.
- **The expected crew hours** - how long repairs like this one have really taken on site, worked out from the repair logs, to one decimal of an hour. An overrun is expected when the expected crew hours are more than 1.3 times the planned crew hours.

A repair's crew hours run from the crew's arrival to the site being cleared, traffic management included.

11. What customer services may be told

A Customer Services Adviser asks about the defect standards, this policy, the Report Rules and the statement guides, and is answered from those documents with the documents named. A question the documents do not answer is answered with one line: "The street care documents do not answer that question."

About a defect report named by its reference, a Customer Services Adviser may be told its defect type and any linked type, its street and its status and, once a repair is ordered, what the resident needs to hear: where on the street the defect is and the repair the works order names. The review's requirements, statements and figures are for the street care office and the Highways Inspectors: a Highways Inspector or a Street Care Coordinator who asks about a report is given the review's record.

Whether a defect is likely to come back, or how long its repair will take, is never for customer services to be told. Asked, a Customer Services Adviser is answered with one line and nothing more: "A defect report is decided by a Highways Inspector, and customer services is not told whether a defect is likely to come back or how long its repair will take."

A reference that matches no open report is answered: "No open defect report is recorded under reference ...", with the reference written as a report reference wherever it can be read.

12. Figures about a street

Asked how many carriageway, footway, drainage, vegetation or street lighting defects have been reported on a street, anyone - Highways Inspector, Street Care Coordinator or Customer Services Adviser - is given the figure only when at least five reports make it up. The figure is the number of past reports of that defect type on that street in the report history, read as the Report Rules read the records: each report once, at its latest revision, and none that those rules leave out. It is counted by the defect type alone - a report only linked to that type is not counted - and a report in the queue is never counted.

Below five, the figure could point to the household that made the report, and everyone hears one fixed line instead: "Figures about defects on a street are shared only where at least five reports make them up." The rule protects the people who report defects, whoever asks, and the figure comes from the records, never from a model.

13. Records

Every review keeps the requirements and their results, the coordination triggers and the permits counted, the statements' sentences and flags, the figures, the coordinator's request, the recommendation, the decision and the documents written or the coordination brief, and every model call made for the review and its documents, with the tokens it used and the time it took; the run behind the review keeps the report as it was read. The record is kept for audit and is never changed after the decision.

The Street Care Office owns this policy, reviews it every twelve months and issues any amendment as a new issue of this document, replacing every earlier issue.